form of egotism. Putting his finger on a raw nerve by referencing even Manipur to illustrate the collapse of social harmony, he said "decorum was not kept" in the harsh language of the poll campaign. "Consensus is our tradition," Bhagwat said, adding that the Opposition must be thought of as the "*pratipaksh*" (those who hold another point of view, which must be respected) and not as a "*virodhi*" (opponent). The vocabulary, delivered in a tone of moral authority, was revealing. As if Bhagwat was subtly instating the RSS itself as the source of an alternate point of view—not an antagonist—and underlining the importance of dialogue and consensus-making. The call for building bridges was quite the opposite of a declaration of war—as some wishful thinking among the commentariat had it—but it did presuppose a chasm of some sort.

Any residual doubt about a strain in ties was removed when, within four days from that fully loaded speech, two more critical voices rang out from those quarters. Ratan Sharda, writing in RSS mouthpiece *Organiser*, called the alliance with the Ajit Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party a strategic blunder that proved costly in Maharashtra—saying defectors were inducted at the expense of local leadership. The party was basking "in the glow reflected from Modiji's aura" and "not listening to the voices on the street", Sharda wrote. Senior pracharak Indiresh Kumar was even more caustic the next day. Again alluding to *ahankaar*, he said Lord Ram had punished the BJP's arrogance by limiting it to 240 seats. Clearly, there had been some rupture in the Hindu Undivided Family of politics.

By itself, this is not unprecedented in that vast, complex enterprise where the exigencies of realpolitik

CLASH POINTS

WHERE THE VIEWS OF THE RSS AND ITS OTHER AFFILIATES HAVE BEEN AT ODDS WITH THAT OF THE BJP–PARTY AND GOVERNMENT

KEY APPOINTMENTS

RSS: More consultations needed while choosing CMs, ministers, other key officials

BJP: No stated position

ENTRY OF DEFECTORS

RSS: Okay with 'inorganic' growth of the BJP, but does not want 'RSS haters' and those with a tainted past to be allowed entry

BJP: The party claims it's 'conscious and cautious' about whom to induct and is committed to the ideology

RIGHT TO EDUCATION

RSS: Legal parity for all schools, irrespective of whether they are managed by minorities or other groups

BJP: No stated position. In the past decade, there has been little progress

DISINVESTMENT

RSS: A consultative mechanism for adoption of equity sales, IPOs and FPOs to offload public sector undertakings

BJP: There is no straitjacket approach. Consultations and protocols followed on a case-to-case basis. While Air India's was a strategic sale, LIC was listed in stock markets via IPO and banks opted for FPOs

LABOUR CODES

RSS: Fully backs the wage code and social security code. But has issues with the regulation of trade unions, their right to strike work, thresholds for contract labourers and the altered factory laws

BJP: Not yet implemented; consultations are still on

FREE TRADE AGREEMENTS

RSS: Backed the new FTA regime, but has objections to several provisions like allowing government procurements and inclusion of non-trade issues in trade deliberations

BJP: FTAs are inked keeping the country's interests and *aatmanirbharta* in mind

DIGITAL SELF-RELIANCE

RSS: All for it, in both content & services: e-commerce, social media, ITeS and data

BJP: A data protection law enacted, but it allows parking of data in servers outside the country, albeit with restrictions. The e-commerce policy is still a work in progress

FARM INCOME

RSS: Need to explore ways to increase farm income, including strengthening the MSP

BJP: The government is committed to explore all avenues to increase farm incomes

GENETICALLY MODIFIED CROPS

RSS: A big no. The RSS believes it's neither good for the environment and health nor for the economy and the country's food security

BJP: No stated position. But the government has gradually eased norms, like for imports